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Unit 6 Assignment

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Children's Literature and Fantasy: A Comparative Analysis of Two Literary Works

Introduction: Children's Literature and Fantasy

Children's literature refers to literary works written primarily for children and young readers. It includes picture books, folktales, fairy tales, poetry, realistic fiction, adventure stories, and educational narratives. Its main purposes may include entertainment, education, moral development, and encouragement of imagination. Fantasy literature, in contrast, is defined mainly by its use of extraordinary or impossible elements, such as talking about animals, supernatural beings, magical objects, and imaginary worlds. Although children's literature and fantasy are different categories, they frequently overlap. For example, a fairy tale featuring a talking animal may entertain children while teaching them about honesty, kindness, or responsibility. However, not all children's literature is fantasy, because realistic stories can address family relationships, school, friendship, and everyday challenges without supernatural elements. Similarly, fantasy is not limited to children because adults also read and appreciate it. "The Story of the Husband and the Parrot" from *The Thousand and One Nights* illustrates this overlap through a talking parrot whose extraordinary ability contributes to a moral lesson about trust and hasty judgment (Getty et al., 2020). Therefore, children's literature is primarily associated with its intended audience and developmental purposes, whereas fantasy is distinguished by its imaginative content and narrative conventions.

Analysis of “The Story of the Husband and the Parrot”

“The Story of the Husband and the Parrot” is a folktale in which a merchant purchases an unusually intelligent parrot to observe his wife while he is away. When the parrot reports what it has witnessed, the wife becomes angry and arranges an illusion of thunder, lightning, and rain to confuse the bird. When the merchant returns, the parrot describes the artificial storm, and the merchant mistakenly believes it is lying. He kills the parrot but later discovers that the bird had previously told the truth, leaving him with regret (Getty et al., 2020).

Vladimir Propp’s theory of folktale structure helps explain how the story develops through characters’ actions. Propp (1968) identified 31 narrative functions that appear in varying combinations across the Russian folktales he studied. These functions include harmful action or villainy, a struggle, the exposure of wrongdoing, and punishment. Not every tale contains all 31 functions, and the theory should not be applied as a rigid checklist. In this story, the wife’s deception resembles a villainous action because she deliberately creates false evidence to discredit the parrot. The merchant’s departure also establishes the situation that allows the conflict to develop. However, the story does not follow the complete structure of a conventional heroic quest: there is no clear hero who defeats a villain and receives a reward. Instead, the narrative emphasizes deception, mistaken judgment, and the tragic consequences of acting without verifying the truth.

Tolkien’s (1964) discussion of fairy-stories provides another perspective. He associates fairy stories with recovery, escape, and consolation. Recovery encourages readers to see familiar experiences from a fresh perspective, while escape offers imaginative movement beyond ordinary reality. The talking parrot provides an element of escape because it possesses an extraordinary ability to observe and report events. At the same time, the story encourages recovery by challenging readers to reconsider jealousy, trust, and the dangers of accepting appearances as truth. However, it offers limited consolation because the parrot’s death cannot be reversed. Its tragic ending demonstrates that not every fantastic folktale provides the happy resolution often associated with fairy-stories.

Analysis of “A Very Old Man with Enormous Wings”

Gabriel García Márquez’s “A Very Old Man with Enormous Wings” presents an extraordinary figure who appears in the ordinary setting of a poor coastal household. Pelayo and Elisenda discover an old man with enormous wings in their courtyard. Rather than responding to him with consistent compassion or understanding, the villagers treat him as curiosity. His presence attracts visitors, and Elisenda eventually profits from the crowds. Over time, the old man becomes less central to their lives, and he finally flies away (Turlington et al., 2022).

Propp’s framework can be applied selectively to this story. The arrival of the winged man disrupts ordinary life and initiates the central conflict. His unusual appearance also creates a situation in which other characters reveal their motivation. Unlike a traditional folktale hero, however, he does not undertake a quest, defeat an opponent, or receive a conventional reward. Instead, the narrative reverses familiar expectations: the apparently extraordinary figure suffers neglect, while ordinary people exploit his presence. This difference shows how a modern fantastic narrative can use elements resembling folktale disruption without following Propp’s complete sequence of functions.

Tolkien’s ideas also illuminate the story, although Márquez’s magical realism differs from a conventional fairy-story. The winged man introduces an extraordinary element into an otherwise recognizable world, encouraging readers to reconsider the boundaries between the possible and impossible. This creates a form of escape through

imaginative uncertainty and promotes recovery by exposing human cruelty, greed, and the tendency to exploit what people do not understand. Nevertheless, the ending does not offer a clear moral victory or the strong consolation of a traditional fairy-tale resolution. The old man's departure leaves readers questioning the villagers' behavior rather than celebrating a hero's triumph.

Conclusion

Children's literature and fantasy overlap when imaginative stories serve young readers' emotional, intellectual, or moral development, but neither category is limited to the other. Propp's theory helps identify narrative functions and patterns, while Tolkien's framework explains how extraordinary stories can renew perception, offer imaginative escape, and sometimes provide consolation. Both selected works use fantastic elements to examine human behavior, yet their structures and endings differ. The parrot tale emphasizes the consequences of deception and rash judgment, whereas Márquez's story uses magical realism to criticize exploitation and indifference. Together, they demonstrate that fantastic literature can entertain readers while encouraging critical reflection on ordinary human experiences.

References

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